Meanwhile, I was getting involved in the investigation deeper and deeper, even as the legend of ‘One-Eyed Jack’, as Sivarasan was sometimes called, grew larger by the day. He managed to stay ahead of the CBI, R&AW, the Intelligence Bureau (IB), Military Intelligence (MI) and state police across the country, in a clear indication that India’s biggest manhunt so far was not good enough to catch him. But one thing was clear to the CBI—Sivarasan was holed up somewhere in India. While the agencies left no stone unturned to find him, the mastermind played his own tricks. He hand-picked his lookalikes from the cadres of his organization and sent them across the country in disguise just to keep the security agencies engaged in chasing ‘him’ to every corner of the country and then return disappointed.

Unlike the SIT, mine was a one-man army, and I was lucky to have the right contacts in the CBI. The SIT boss Kaarthikeyan was not too happy with my ‘overenthusiastic’ approach to staying ahead of rival publications but would rarely refuse to grant me an appointment. However, covering the developments on the trail of the assassin had become equally challenging for me. I didn’t know which lead to follow and which to ignore. However, the relentless chase brought hope when the Indian Navy intercepted a coded communication between Madras and Jaffna, indicating that Sivarasan was asking his boss, Pottu Amman, in Jaffna for a boat. But the breakthrough was short-lived. Sivarasan discovered his communication with Jaffna was being intercepted by the Indian security agencies. As I wrote in one of my stories in the *India Today* magazine,

> Instead of ceasing transmission, he used the knowledge to run rings around the SIT. On one occasion, the SIT rushed a 60-man force to Pulicat lake on the Tamil Nadu-Andhra Pradesh border. They combed every inch of the 600 sq km lake only to find they had been handed another red herring.[2]

The Robert Ludlum-like plot continued to thicken, and the tasks and targets kept multiplying. Raids by the SIT’s tracking team kept failing. Fingers